MEATY FIGURES

- According to the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) 2019-21, 49.3% of men and 39.3% women consumed fish, chicken or meat every week
- The numbers for those who had never consumed non-vegetarian food was just 16.6% and 29.4%, respectively

83.4% men and 70.6% women in the 15-49 age group eat non-vegetarian food

- Data shows 'gradual rise' in non-veg consumption. NFHS 2015-16 had 43.2% men and 36.6% women as meat-eaters
- Meat now a big contributor to economy. Exports of animal products in FY24: $4.5 billion (Rs 38,424 cr.), of which buffalo meat contributed $3.7 billion (Rs 31,593 cr.)
- A 2023-24 GoI report says India is No. 5 globally in meat production, with 4.5 million tonnes produced a year; in egg production, it's No. 2 behind China with 142.8 bn eggs

while halal comes from Islam and was forced on us," parrots Akash Palange, spokesperson of the Hindu Dalit Khatik Mahasangh, which has launched the Malhar certification. He alleges that around 90 per cent of the Hindu Khatiks, who are Dalits, had to quit their traditional meat business due to the insistence on halal meat. "We are not opposing halal...we are just calling on Hindus to consume jhatka meat as a form of economic support for Hindu Khatiks," he says. So far, around 150 meat-sellers across Maharashtra have registered for the certification, and Palange claims the numbers will rise. They are asking the government to allocate space for them in city slaughterhouses. A Pune-based butcher who did not want to be named says traditionally, only the Sikhs and Punjabis asked for jhatka meat, adding that there had been more inquiries from Hindus after the Malhar brouhaha.

Shabbir Ahmed Ansari of the All India Muslim OBC Organisation notes that while Muslims may be slaughtering the animals, they had only a small role in the larger pink economy. It was the Hindus and Jains who were in the export business, running factories making products from animal bones. Ishaque Khadke, secretary of the Muslim Khatik Samaj, Maharashtra, points out that many Hindu butchers sold halal meat slaughtered by their Muslim counterparts. "Around 80 per cent of society is being held hostage to the whims of a handful," he says.

The halal versus jhatka debate is also gaining traction on the margins in Bengal, but in other subtle ways. The BJP frequently invokes the memory of Gopal Chandra Mukhopadhyay, better known as Gopal Pantha, a butcher remembered for his role during the 'Direct Action Day' riots in 1946. While the BJP holds him up as a hero who faced up to Muslim aggression, many others consider him a hoodlum whose legacy is mired in bloodshed. The 'beef ban' doesn't have many takers in Bengal, although the right-wing ecosystem continues to weave subtle narratives linking its consumption to Muslim appeasement by the ruling Trinamool Congress.

But even with all this, no one, especially in the government, seems to be complaining about how meat is also now a huge contributor to the economy, with buffalo meat dominating exports of animal products at 82 per cent in 2023-24. Exports in FY24 was worth $4.5 billion (Rs 38,424 crore), of which buffalo meat was $3.7 billion (Rs 31,593 crore), followed by sheep/goat meat ($77.7 million), other meats ($0.8 million), and poultry products ($184.6 million). Meat production grew 4.9 per cent year on year to 10.3 million tonnes in the same period. Egg production also rose 3.2 per cent to 142.8 billion. Per capita egg consumption has also grown from 101 to 103 per annum.

Past is Not the Past

The politicisation of food contrasts starkly with India's historical relationship with meat. Indologist Nrisingha Prasad Bhaduri points out that meat consumption has deep roots in Indian culture, dating back to the Vedas. "The Rig Veda mentions the sacrifice and consumption of horse, ox and sheep," he says. "Which part of the animal was to be consumed by whom is also detailed. The switch to milk was a nutritional choice, not a religious mandate." These references are also found in the Valmiki Ramayana, and many Puranas even describe meat being offered during funeral rites. According to Bhaduri, vegetarianism began to take deeper roots with the advent of Buddhism, which strictly forbade the killing of animals.

EVEN AS THE MEAT BATTLES CONTINUE, NO ONE SEEMS TO BE COMPLAINING ABOUT HOW ITS EXPORT BROUGHT IN $4.5 BN IN FY24

In Bengal, the culture of meat/fish-eating is deeply intertwined with spiritual life. The goddess Kali has historically been worshipped with 'offerings'—in extreme cases, even human sacrifices. "In the old days, dacoits offered human sacrifices before going out on raids," Bhaduri notes, referring to the 'Dakate Kali' tradition. His view is that faith has always accommodated regional custom. Quoting from the Ramayana, he says: "*Yadanya purusha rajan, tadanyastsya devata* (As is the man, so is his deity)." Unfortunately, ancient wisdom is lost in the din of the politics of the day where even a person or community's dietary habits can become easy meat for vigilantes. ■

-with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Avaneesh Mishra & Rahul Noronha